

Clinical Dialogue Transcript — ADHD

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THERAPIST (Turn 1)

Hi, thanks for coming in today. What's been going on for you lately?

PATIENT (Turn 2)

It's just... everything, I guess. I'm just having a hard time getting anything done. I'll start on a task, but then I'll get sidetracked and watch a video or something. And then I'll be like, "Oh, I'll just do this one thing real quick," and the next thing I know, hours have passed and I haven't accomplished anything. I'm just... bad at adulting, I don't know. (pauses) Did I mention I just got a new coffee mug and it's really pretty?

THERAPIST (Turn 3)

It sounds like you're feeling really overwhelmed and frustrated with yourself right now. It's completely normal to get sidetracked, especially when tasks feel daunting or uninteresting. This "bad at adulting" feeling is something a lot of people experience, so you're definitely not alone in that.

I notice you shifted to talking about your new coffee mug—it's interesting how our minds sometimes steer us toward things that feel comforting or rewarding in the moment, like a small pleasure or distraction. That's actually a really human thing to do when we're feeling stressed or stuck.

Can you tell me more about what kinds of tasks feel the hardest to focus on? Are there certain emotions or thoughts that come up when you're trying to get things done? For example, do you feel anxious, bored, or maybe even a little numb?

PATIENT (Turn 4)

Tasks, huh... I don't know, they just feel so... long. And boring. I'll be like, "Okay, I'll just do this one thing," and then I'll be stuck on it for hours, but I won't be doing it, you know? I'll be thinking about something else the whole time. (trails off) Oh, I just remembered I need to pick up some milk on the way home. I'm out of it and my partner's been leaving me notes about it everywhere...

THERAPIST (Turn 5)

It sounds like your mind is doing that thing where it's trying to protect you from the discomfort of those long, boring tasks by pulling you into distractions or even other responsibilities—like remembering the milk. It's like your brain is saying, *"This feels overwhelming or tedious, so let's focus on something else instead."*

And those little notes from your partner about the milk—while they're coming from a place of care, I can imagine they might also feel like tiny reminders of all the things you're "supposed" to be doing, which can add to the pressure.

I'm curious: when you're in the middle of one of these tasks and your mind starts wandering, what's the emotion underneath that? Do you feel restless, frustrated, or maybe even a little hopeless? Or does it feel more like your brain just **checks out**?

PATIENT (Turn 6)

Restless, I guess. And a little frustrated. But not in a, "I'm really mad at myself" way, just more like... I don't know, I'll be sitting there and my brain will be like, "Come on, just focus," but I won't be able to. And then I'll feel like I'm wasting time, but I'm not really doing anything. It's hard to explain. (pauses) Wait, I just thought of something – I need to call my sister and return her call from yesterday. I keep putting it off because I don't know what to say...

THERAPIST (Turn 7)

That restlessness you're describing makes a lot of sense—it's like your mind and body are stuck in this tug-of-war between "I **should** focus" and "I just can't right now." And that frustration isn't about anger at yourself; it's more like your system is protesting against the monotony or the pressure. It's almost like your brain is saying, *"This isn't engaging me, so I'm going to find something that does."*

And then there's the call to your sister—it's interesting how that popped into your mind right now. It feels like another example of how your brain is trying to juggle all these little responsibilities, even when you're already feeling stretched thin. Sometimes, tasks like calling someone back can feel heavy because they come with uncertainty ("What do I say?") or even a fear of judgment ("What if she's upset I didn't call sooner?").

Would it help to explore what makes these tasks feel so draining? For example, is it the *length* of the task, the lack of immediate reward, or something else? And with the call to your sister, what's the worst-case scenario you're imagining if you reach out? Sometimes naming those fears can take some of their power away.

PATIENT (Turn 8)

I don't know... it's just that when I'm in the middle of something, I feel like I'm just going through the motions, you know? It's like my brain is on autopilot, but my body is still stuck in the same old patterns. And yeah, the uncertainty is a big part of it – like, what if I say the wrong thing? What if she's mad at me? (pauses) But I guess the worst-case scenario is just that I'll feel even more anxious and overwhelmed afterwards. (gets slightly defensive) I mean, I'm trying to be responsible here...

THERAPIST (Turn 9)

It sounds like you're carrying a lot of pressure to "get it right" and be responsible, which can make even small tasks feel like they have high stakes. That autopilot feeling you described is really common—it's like your brain is trying to conserve energy by going through the motions, but your emotions are still stuck in the background, whispering (or sometimes shouting) that something feels off or uncomfortable.

And that defensive tone makes sense too—it's like your system is saying, *"I'm already doing my best, why is this still so hard?"* That frustration isn't about you failing; it's about how exhausting it is to constantly navigate uncertainty and self-doubt.

What if, instead of trying to "be responsible" in the way you think you *should*, we explored what responsibility could look like *for you* in a way that feels more manageable? For example, with your sister, could you start with a simple text like, *"Hey, I've been thinking about you—wanted to call but didn't know what to say. Can we chat soon?"* That takes the pressure off having to have the "perfect" conversation right away.

Would that feel like a relief, or does it still feel like too much?

PATIENT (Turn 10)

(pausing, slightly softer) Yeah, that sounds... doable, I guess. I mean, it's not like I'm trying to avoid my sister or anything – I just don't know where to start, you know? (laughs nervously) And yeah, that text sounds like a good way to start. It's not like I'm committing to a whole conversation right away. (pauses again) But you know what would be nice? If I could just find a system that works for organizing stuff. I've tried so many apps and to-do lists, but they all just end up feeling like more clutter...

THERAPIST (Turn 11)

I love that you're already seeing how breaking things into smaller steps—like that text—can feel more manageable. It's not about avoiding the conversation; it's about giving yourself permission to start *where you are*, not where you think you *should* be.

And that frustration with systems and to-do lists? That's so relatable. It's like we're sold this idea that if we just find the *perfect* app or planner, everything will magically fall into place—but then it just becomes another thing to manage, another source of guilt when it doesn't work. What if, instead of looking for the "perfect" system, we focused on what feels *simple and sustainable* for *you*?

For example, some people find it helpful to:

- **Time-block** just 10-15 minutes for a task (with a timer!) to make it feel less daunting.
- **Pair tasks with something enjoyable**, like listening to music or a podcast while doing chores.
- **Use a "brain dump" list**—just scribbling down everything on your mind in one place so it's not swirling around in your head.

Would any of those feel like a good fit, or is there something else that's worked for you in the past (even if it didn't last)?

PATIENT (Turn 12)

(sighs) Yeah, I guess that makes sense. I mean, I've tried all those things before, but they just feel like... Band-Aids, you know? They don't really address the underlying stuff. (pauses) But, actually, I did find something that worked for me once. I used to work with a friend on a project, and we would have these big whiteboards where we'd just list out all the tasks we needed to do. And then we'd break them down into smaller steps, and just start doing them one by one. It felt... simple, I guess. Not like I was trying to tackle everything at once. (looks away) But, I don't know, it was just a one-time thing... I don't know if it would work in real life.

THERAPIST (Turn 13)

It's really insightful that you noticed how working with your friend on that whiteboard felt different—*simpler, more manageable*. That's not just a Band-Aid; that's actually a really effective strategy called **"externalizing"**—getting the chaos out of your head and onto something tangible, like a whiteboard or a piece of paper. It takes the pressure off your brain to hold everything at once.

And the fact that it worked for you before suggests that this isn't about you being "bad at adulting" or incapable of focus—it's about finding the *right conditions* for your brain to thrive. For example:

- **Collaboration** (having someone else there) might have made it feel less overwhelming.

- **Visualizing tasks** (the whiteboard) gave you a clear starting point.
- **Breaking things down** made the work feel less abstract.

Would it feel worth experimenting with that again, even in a small way? For example, could you try using a whiteboard (or even a notebook) to map out just *one* area of your life that feels overwhelming right now? You don't have to commit to solving everything—just see if it brings back that sense of clarity you felt before.

Or, if collaboration was the key, could you ask a friend or your partner to be an "accountability buddy" for a short time, just to help you get started on something? What do you think?

PATIENT (Turn 14)

(slowly nods) Yeah, I think that could work. I mean, it's not like I'm afraid to ask for help or anything. It's just... (pauses) I don't know, it feels like I'm supposed to be able to have all the answers, you know? But, I guess that's not true. (smirks slightly) And yeah, having someone else there might make it feel less overwhelming. I could ask my partner to help me set up a whiteboard or something. (looks down) But, what if we get stuck, or I mess it up? (looks up) Wait, I just remembered I have a friend who's really organized and stuff. Maybe I could ask her to check in with me on some of these tasks...

THERAPIST (Turn 15)

It sounds like you're starting to give yourself permission to explore what *actually* works for you, rather than what you think "should" work—and that's a really important shift. That idea that you're "supposed to have all the answers" is such a common trap, but it's also a myth. Even the most organized people need support sometimes.

And I love that you're already brainstorming ways to make this feel more doable:

- **Partner collaboration** (whiteboard setup) could help with the initial overwhelm.
- **Friend check-ins** might add that layer of accountability and encouragement.

That "what if we get stuck or I mess it up?" question is so valid. What do you think would be the *worst* that could happen if you tried one of these things and it didn't go perfectly? For example, if you and your partner set up the whiteboard and it feels messy or unhelpful at first, could you see that as just *information*—like, "Okay, this part didn't work, so let's tweak it"?

Also, how would it feel to frame this as an *experiment* rather than a test you have to pass? For example: *"Let's try this whiteboard thing for a week and see what happens. No pressure to get it right—just see what we learn."* Would that take some of the pressure off?

PATIENT (Turn 16)

(exhales slowly) I don't know, I guess it's just that I'm used to feeling like I'm failing, even when I'm trying. But if I frame this as an experiment, like you said, that might help. It's not like I'm going to be graded or anything. (smirks slightly) And yeah, if it doesn't work out, I can just say, "Okay, that didn't work, let's try something else." (pauses) It's funny, just thinking about it this way is making me feel a little lighter. Like, maybe I don't have to have all the answers. Maybe I can just... figure it out as I go. (looks up) That feels kind of okay, I guess.

THERAPIST (Turn 17)

I love that you're noticing how much lighter it feels to approach this as an **experiment** rather than a test. That shift—from "I have to get this right" to "Let's see what happens"—can take so much pressure off. It's like giving yourself permission to be a **learner** instead of someone who's supposed to already know everything.

And that smirk? That's your system saying, *"Okay, this might actually be doable."* It's a small but powerful sign that you're reconnecting with your own agency—your ability to try things, adjust, and figure it out as you go.

So, what's one small step you could take this week to play with this idea? For example:

- Could you ask your partner to help you set up that whiteboard, just for one area of your life (like chores or errands)?
- Could you reach out to your organized friend and say, *"Hey, I'm trying to get better at this—would you be up for a quick check-in this week?"*
- Or even just jotting down a few tasks on paper to see how it feels to "externalize" them?

You don't have to commit to a big overhaul—just one tiny experiment to see what works. What feels most doable to you right now?

PATIENT (Turn 18)

(smirks slightly) Yeah, I think I could ask my partner to help me set up that whiteboard. Just for one area, like chores or errands. (pauses) It's not like it's a huge ask, and it's something we can do together. (nods) Yeah, that feels doable. And if it doesn't work out, we can just... change it. (smiles slightly) I like that idea.

THERAPIST (Turn 19)

That's the spirit! Starting small—just one area, like chores or errands—makes it feel so much more manageable. And doing it **together** with your partner takes the pressure off you to figure it all out alone. It's not about getting it "perfect"; it's about giving yourself a chance to see what works and what doesn't.

I love how you're already embracing the idea of flexibility: **"If it doesn't work out, we can just change it."** That's the beauty of an experiment—it's not a final judgment on your abilities; it's just information to help you move forward.

So, when do you think you might try this? And how will you know if it's helping? For example, would it feel like less mental clutter, or maybe just a sense of progress, even if it's small? Either way, I'm curious to hear how it goes—no pressure, just curiosity!

PATIENT (Turn 20)

(laughs) Yeah, no pressure! I think I'll try to set up the whiteboard with my partner this weekend. We can take a look at our chores and errands and see if we can organize them in a way that feels more manageable.

(pauses) I don't know, but I think it would feel good to have a clear plan for once. And if it doesn't work out, like you said, we can just change it. (smiles slightly) I'm just looking forward to feeling like I'm making progress, even if it's small.

THERAPIST (Turn 21)

That sounds like a fantastic plan! The fact that you're already looking forward to that sense of progress—even if it's small—is a great sign. It's like you're giving yourself permission to celebrate the **process** of figuring things out, not just the outcome.

And I love how you're approaching this with curiosity and teamwork. That whiteboard isn't just about chores; it's about creating a little more space in your mind and your relationship to tackle things together. Even if it's not perfect, just the act of trying something new is a win.

Would it help to check in with yourself after the weekend to see how it felt? For example, you could ask:

- **What was it like to set this up together?**
- **Did anything feel easier or harder than expected?**
- **What's one thing you'd want to adjust or try differently next time?**

No matter how it goes, I'm really glad you're giving yourself this chance to experiment. You've got this—and I'm here if you want to debrief afterward!